

# The Sūtra of the Great Vehicle, King of the True Dharma

Saddharmarāja Mahāyāna Sūtra · Toh 243 · Derge Kangyur

དམ་པའི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་པ་ཐོག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མཛན་

The Sūtra of the Great Vehicle, King of the True Dharma, known in Sanskrit as the Saddharmarāja Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Dampé Chökyi Gyalpo Tekpa Chenpo'i Do, is a Mahāyāna sūtra set at the most solemn of moments: the Buddha's imminent passing into final nirvāṇa beneath the two śāla trees. In it, the Buddha emits a great radiance that directly reveals all phenomena to an assembled multitude, and the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha, the Treasury of Space, rises among the gathered beings to receive and engage with these final teachings. The text belongs to the class of Mahāyāna sūtras concerned with the Buddha's parinirvāṇa and the profound Dharma he imparts in those last moments. It is catalogued as Toh 243 in the Kangyur, preserved among the general Mahāyāna sūtras of that collection.

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In the language of India: Saddharmarāja Mahāyāna Sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Sūtra of the Great Vehicle, King of the True Dharma.

At that time, the Buddha was dwelling between the two śāla trees, on the verge of passing into nirvāṇa. Countless hundreds of thousands of myriads of sentient beings were gathered there, surrounding the Buddha at the foot of the trees, their eyes raised, gazing up into the face of the Blessed One without the slightest distraction. Then the Tathāgata, by the power of his miraculous ability, sent forth a great radiance that illuminated and pervaded the entire expanse of space. From within that light he directly revealed all phenomena. At that time, among the great assembly, there was a bodhisattva named Ākāśagarbha, the Treasury of Space. He rose from his seat, circumambulated the Buddha three times, then sat back down facing him, his five lower limbs touching the ground, weeping with tears streaming down his face, and made this supplication to the Buddha:

Most Venerable One, Tathāgata, among the gods — the time of your passing into nirvāṇa draws near, and it will come with ease. Yet on account of your passing, sentient beings of the five turbidities commit many unwholesome deeds and practice all ten non-virtues without exception. For such sentient beings, though the brilliance of the power of beautiful virtue shines, the Buddha has taught the extremely profound true Dharma in twelve textual

divisions, and the words of these texts are many while the treatises are vast, making them difficult to comprehend and difficult to study. Even if one were to read all these teachings, one still could not keep pace with them. Therefore, in your love and compassion, may the Buddha teach a precise distinction of the true Dharma of the Great Vehicle and thereby enable sentient beings to obtain the excellent true medicine, so that every last affliction of sickness may be healed. This is my aspiration.

The Buddha then spoke to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, by being able to ask such a question of great import on behalf of sentient beings, you have obtained great merit — immeasurable and inconceivable. I shall explain to you in full the true teaching, the precise distinction of the Dharma of the Great Vehicle, the complete and immutable treatise. Why? In order to liberate sentient beings extensively; in order to free sentient beings from sorrow; in order to draw sentient beings out from the afflictions of the hells and have them be reborn in pure lands; and in order that they may be perfectly liberated, freed from birth and death. All of you, concentrate your minds as one, and I shall explain it so that you will understand.

Then the entire great assembly, filled with great joy and delight, spoke in one voice from their various mouths in unison: May the Buddha, in his love and compassion, teach us this precise distinction. The Buddha then spoke: Noble sons, if you wish to be liberated and freed, cut away the limbs of desire, think of the mind not as two but as one, and let go of the mind that entertains the thought of existence. The essential nature of mind is empty. Within the essential nature of mind there is nothing that arrives and nothing that departs. Where there is nothing to take up and nothing to let go, there is nothing whatsoever to be obtained. This is called awakening. How so? The great mass of sorrow all arises from a single mind. When the mind does not conceptualize, sorrow too does not arise. Toward the sense sources and wisdom, there is nothing to take up and nothing to let go. Where there is nothing to take up and nothing to let go, one is free of all attachment and desire. Where one is free of all attachment and desire, there are no longer limbs of desire.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Buddha: Blessed One, the sense sources and wisdom of sentient beings are capable of giving rise to virtue and non-virtue, and they are the very site from which responses and reactions arise. All the phenomena of both outer and inner, both extremes, enter one into the other. Why then is it appropriate to say that within them there is

nothing to take up and nothing to let go?

The Buddha then spoke to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: Son of good family, enter into the inward space where meditation is gathered into one, and when all things are examined inwardly and outwardly, no endpoint is reached. Why is this? When one looks inward and examines inward, there is no arising within the essential nature of reality. When one looks outward and examines outward, ignorance does not stir. Where there is no arising and no stirring, there is likewise no nirvāṇa — and that is what is pure and clear. That is the medicine of supreme joy.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Buddha: Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the truly gone one, has taught the authentic form of the Dharma of the Great Vehicle — profound and precious, the supreme and excellent medicine — and has taught entry into the truth of the one vehicle. But the sentient beings of ages to come, having acted through three impure kinds of action and having performed the ten non-virtues, and having engaged in the deeds of wrong craving, are weak and feeble at the root and foundation. It is hard for the mind to hold even a dhāraṇī. If the medicine and the illness happen not to be compatible, what means should be employed so that entry into the Great Vehicle is possible?

The Buddha spoke to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: I have means, and by them one may enter into the Great Vehicle.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha asked the Buddha: Blessed One, I have heard it said of old that the Tathāgata, the truly gone one, taught the Dharma of the six perfections to people of the Great Vehicle, taught the Dharma of the twelve links of cause and condition to people of the middle vehicle, taught the Dharma of the Four Noble Truths to people of the lesser vehicle, and taught the Dharma of the ten virtues to people of wrong craving — and in each case, having matched it to the bodily condition of the illness, taught the excellent medicine of Dharma. Why then would one teach the Dharma of the one vehicle and make these four kinds of people the target of a single arrow?

The Buddha spoke to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: My teaching of the Dharma of the path of the one vehicle is like the earth, which can produce all that exists and nourish everything. It is further like the moisture of a rain of Dharma spreading over all things, so that all that grows from the earth is satisfied. It is like the broth boiled from a single kind of grain, which all the sentient beings of the world — both human and non-human — eat; and when

all have eaten, the body of each comes into being and the life of each is sustained. This bringing of all into being is like a king of medicines: a physician skilled in compounding takes all the most precious and excellent medicines and combines them. When this is given to sentient beings struck by fever, it cools and refreshes. When given to sentient beings struck by a cold illness, it warms. When given to those afflicted with inflammation, it cuts it off. When given to those with cramps, it loosens them — there is no illness it cannot cure. My teaching of the one vehicle, which heals the root illnesses of such people, is exactly like this.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha asked the Buddha: Blessed One, what means should be employed to lead those of the ten non-virtues and sentient beings of wrong craving onto the path of the single vehicle?

The Buddha spoke to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: Son of good family, within the Dharma of my one vehicle the three vehicles are present. Beyond that, there is no separately spoken thing called "the three vehicles." Listen and reflect carefully, for I shall explain this to you in detail. Son of good family, all the various paths of the sacred Dharma share a single essential nature at the base — and since there is no duality, it is spoken of as three vehicles only as a matter of skillful means. Contemplate how all the phenomena of the three vehicles are gathered into one. Although sentient beings, every one of them, have four aspects, in the essential nature of buddhahood there is no duality. How is this? The essential nature of all buddhas and the essential nature of all sentient beings are in perfect accord as one.

They are one sūtra. Since there is no distinction among sentient beings, it is the movement of sentient beings' own minds that sets differentiation and division in motion. Ultimately, a buddha is also a sentient being, and a sentient being is also a buddha; every single sentient being possesses the essential nature of buddhahood. The essential nature of buddhahood and the essential nature of sentient beings — these two are one, perfectly equal and identical in essential nature. Because all phenomena are likewise equal, I have the means, and so one should enter the single vehicle. Son of good family, draw the minds of those sentient beings firmly within the citadel of the mind, and let no thief enter. Guard the great gates of the six consciousnesses with the vajra, and examine the place where the mind abides. When one knows the place where the mind abides, in that very place the mind does not abide. If the mind does not abide there, then originally there was no abiding of the mind at all. The mind does not abide in any of the realms of suffering, and if the mind does not

abide in the sense sources and elements, then there is no mind of the branches of desire. If there are no branches of desire, then there is no desiring and seeking of the mind. If there is no seeking in the mind, then the mind does not abide anywhere at all. If it does not abide anywhere, then from the very beginning that very thing is named the abiding of the mind.

Son of good family, all the suffering that sentient beings' minds have created has arisen by being stirred up from consciousness, and that is the answer to why the mind does not abide. If the mind abides, then originally there is no suffering either. If there is no suffering, then from the very beginning that is awakening.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha asked the Blessed One: Blessed One, through the power of what is it that all sentient beings, having created all this suffering with their minds not abiding, then give rise to the branches of desire? I aspire that the Blessed One, regarding them with loving-kindness and compassion, will liberate and teach the great many.

The Blessed One declared: Because the branches of the mind of all sentient beings are stirred, there are two powers of intrinsic nature. What are these two? The first is the intrinsic-nature power of the branches of the mind that is stirred owing to the sense sources. The second is the self-arising power of intrinsic nature, which, because the self's mind has not yet arisen for the sake of the sense sources, arises by itself — and that is the intrinsic-nature power of the self.

Son of good family, if those two intrinsic natures of sentient beings are kept from stirring, then from the very beginning there is no suffering and there is no awakening either. If there is neither suffering nor awakening, then one enters directly into the state of perfectly true reality, and that is genuine awakening. When you and the other bodhisattvas teach and guide a sentient being, show that the mind abides.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha asked the Blessed One: Blessed One, if one teaches and guides a sentient being so that their mind abides, in which element does it abide so that they may attain awakening?

The Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, to ask such a question as this — a question about the mother of mind — you are a bodhisattva, a great being, beyond all conception. Listen and examine this, and I shall explain it to you in detail.

Son of good family, in teaching and guiding a sentient being so that the mind abides, the abiding is neither inside, nor outside, nor in between. The Great Vehicle Dharma of all buddhas, likewise, is neither inside, nor outside, nor in between. Resting in the single awareness of the mind, abiding in the place of non-existence, one attains awakening. Even though awakening is attained, there is no coming of any attaining of awakening, and that is named genuine non-stirring.

How is this? Suffering arises from what is untrue, and suffering is therefore empty. All phenomena, moreover, have no self-arising, and phenomena are therefore empty. What is called mind, right now, is nothing more than a name that exists — it cannot be obtained — and mind too is therefore empty. Son of good family, when one recognizes that the mind is empty,

it is not fitting to look upon all that is untrue from within the one empty mind. If one looks upon everything, that is called the defilement of mind. When mind has no defilement, that is called the exhaustion of all outflows (āsrava). The eye, form, and mind — all three are empty. They are forever pure.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if all phenomena are seen in just that way, then it is fitting that all sentient beings — one body, one mind, one element — can enter into the element of a single buddha. And it is fitting that, from the element of a single buddha, through the emptiness that pervades, one can enter into the dharmadhātu of all buddhas."

The Blessed One then spoke to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Son of good family, all elements can be gathered into one element. One element, one lotus throne, and the one body of a Sugata can pervade and fill all elements. When all elements are directly revealed, each and every one is empty. The good sphere of all buddhas can likewise be adorned. The body of a single bodhisattva can pervade and fill all elements. All elements can fit inside the hollow of a single hair follicle. All elements can be gathered into one element, and can fit inside the body of a single sentient being. All elements can be filled by the Dharma qualities of a single buddha, and by the tree of awakening of a single buddha. A single melodious sound can fill all elements, and all can hear and know it in just that way and find delight. Those who practice the Dharma, when they know that the Dharma fills in just that way, should not seek the body of a buddha in the realms of other places — it is fitting to seek the body of a buddha in the abode of the one mind and the one element. From within the one body, the bodies of all can arise. From within the bodies of all, the one

body can arise. How is this? The one body is the body of a single buddha. All the many bodies are the bodies of sentient beings, and therefore all are born from the one mind. When the one mind alone is virtuous, all phenomena are exhaustively virtuous. When the one mind ultimately becomes non-virtuous, all phenomena are exhaustively non-virtuous. If evil karma is performed, one is born in the body of an evil sentient being. If virtuous karma is performed, one is born in the body of a god or human. When the one mind alone is separated from the form of the one mind, it is empty within the form of mind — nothing whatsoever is obtained. When one is further separated from the element of emptiness, the ground of nothing to be taken up is where the body of a buddha can arise. The body of a buddha amounts to no more than one body; there is no duality. The essential nature of all buddhas is one. Within that one essential nature of buddhas, the essential nature of mind amounts solely to one. Apart from the one mind alone, there is nothing to seek elsewhere. If one seeks elsewhere, that is crooked and dishonest. How is this? All the qualities of mind are not to be sought from outside. If they are sought from an outer location, that is called 'other.' If sought from an other's location, that is untrue.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if it is fitting that awakening be attained from within the one mind, then within the mind of all — since the essential nature of buddhahood exists in every one — if the essential nature of buddhahood exists in all sentient beings without exception, and all the Sugatas practice by means of the one mind alone, then every sentient being is capable of generating it. If, within a single mind and a single body, confusion is dispelled, there is no other Dharma of a buddha to be found — it is as though the dharmakāya of a buddha is born within the body itself."

The buddha then declared to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Son of good family, that is so, that is so. Just as you have said: the essential nature of buddhahood exists in every sentient being. All the buddhas, the perfectly gone ones, have each practiced by means of the one mind alone. And by directing the minds of all sentient beings, every one of them, to seek the Dharma of the buddha within the one mind alone, they have attained the body of a buddha."

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, since the essential nature of buddhahood exists in sentient beings, and since buddhahood is attained by searching within the essential nature of

buddhahood itself — then within the individual mind of every sentient being, there too is a buddha. Is it not fitting that one may attain it or see it?"

The buddha then declared to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Son of good family, as for entering authentically and genuinely into the sacred form of the essential nature of buddhahood — it is not fitting to say 'it is attained,' nor is it fitting to say 'it is not attained.' It is not fitting to say 'it is seen,' nor is it fitting to say 'it is not seen.' How so? If a bodhisattva says 'the essential nature of buddhahood exists,' that is a slander of the buddha. If a bodhisattva says 'the essential nature of buddhahood does not exist,' that too is a slander of the buddha. If one says 'the essential nature of buddhahood is not existent,' that too is a slander of the buddha. And if one says 'the essential nature of buddhahood is absent,' that too is a slander of the buddha.

How so? If a bodhisattva says that the essential nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is not existent, it is comparable to space — for space is permanently present. If he says it is not non-existent, it is comparable to a rabbit's horn — for a rabbit's horn can never come to be. Space is permanently present, yet it does not have the character of form. Space's character is not non-present. When it is free of all characteristics of form, there is no attachment to anything whatsoever. It does not abide in the place of arising — if one sees arising in it, that is defilement. It does not abide in the place of non-existence — if one fails to see it there, that is called annihilation.

Such is the sacred form of the essential nature of buddhahood in sentient beings. To say 'the essential nature of buddhahood exists' is to inflate it and slander it. To say 'the essential nature of buddhahood does not exist' is to belittle it and slander it. To say 'the essential nature of buddhahood both exists and does not exist' is to slander it perversely. And to say 'the essential nature of buddhahood is neither existent nor non-existent' is to slander it as a contradictory absurdity."

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the sacred essential nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is thus profound. Since it is free of all conditioned things, it can be stained by nothing whatsoever. It is comparable to space. Since its ultimate essential nature is forever pure, why is it that sentient beings have suffered grief and sorrow? And if they have suffered grief, is not the mind itself thereby defiled? From where did that defilement of mind originally arise? The Blessed One has explained this to many, and all the classes of sentient beings have heard and



come to know it. I now wish for something to relieve the sorrow of the classes of sentient beings. Through the washing away of the defilements of mind, may even those who are covered and bound be freed."

Then the buddha smiled gently, and with his left hand stroked the crown of the bodhisattva's head. He then sent forth a great light that spread out and pervaded everything everywhere. And thereupon all the many sentient beings, every one of them, were filled with exceeding joy and delight.

The buddha then spoke, saying that the question which the bodhisattva had asked on behalf of sentient beings is called asking rightly, and that this leads to the liberation of sentient beings. But if one asks with different words, that is called asking crookedly, and it leads to the ruin of sentient beings. O bodhisattva, by being able to ask rightly, you have brought sentient beings to liberation. Now, let all of you — sentient beings alike — gather the mind into one and attend carefully. Lay aside the scattered and agitated mind, abandon all concern for outward things, and let the mind rest in itself at ease. I will now speak to you. Whoever hears this teaching will bring all sentient beings of the ten evil kinds to liberation and freedom.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, I and the great many sentient beings here have all gathered our minds into one. There is no further agitation of mind. May the Blessed One now speak and bring liberation to the many.

The Blessed One then declared to the bodhisattva and to the many assembled: All sorrow arises from inversion. All inversion arises from an untrue mind. All untrue mind arises from the existence of I. All existence of I arises from the absence of a mother. All that is without a mother is simply non-existence. If there is no mother, then existence is not. Existence is defilement. Non-existence is purity. The abode of that purity is the perfection of permanence. It is the perfection of happiness. It is the perfection of self. It is the perfection of purity. To see in this way is called seeing rightly. To see otherwise is called seeing crookedly. One who sees in this way has wisdom. One who sees otherwise has no wisdom. One who has wisdom is freed through skillful means. One who lacks wisdom is bound through skillful means.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Blessed One: Blessed One, are there not some sentient beings who, dwelling in that abode of purity, stir the mind of permanent permanence, stir the mind of permanent happiness, stir the mind of permanent self, and stir the mind of permanent purity? Do they

not have wisdom, and are they not free of inversion?

The buddha replied to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: There are indeed some sentient beings who think in just that way, and this is called thinking rightly. Such a person sees rightly, and such a person has wisdom. How so? The dharmakāya of the Tathāgata is a body that is permanent — the perfection of permanence, the perfection of happiness, the perfection of self, the perfection of purity — and it abides in utter purity. A person who sees the dharmakāya of the buddhas in just this way is the one true disciple of the buddha. Such a one is born from Dharma, arises through Dharma, is born from the mouth of the buddha, and attains the four foundations of the buddhas. Though an ordinary person, by reason of those four foundations that one is a bodhisattva.

O sons of noble family, whether it be five hundred years after my passing, or a thousand years, or fifteen hundred years, or even thereafter, should some person uphold the text of this Dharma, be able to recite and read it aloud, and practice it as it is taught, placing trust in the abode of permanence, happiness, self, and purity and seeing rightly — if such a one practices this Dharma and then teaches and trains even a single sentient being, that one's name is bodhisattva. Though an ordinary person, it is fitting to receive offerings, and such a one is a person who has gone forth from the household.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Blessed One: Blessed One, does not "a person who has gone forth from the household" mean one who has shaved hair and beard, donned the Dharma robe, and resolved to maintain complete ethical discipline without being stained by the ways of the ordinary?

As for the phrase "worthy of receiving offerings": the Blessed One (the Sugata, the Well-Gone) has now explained that such a person, though an ordinary individual, has gone forth from the household. Since the particular meaning of "worthy of receiving offerings" has not yet been fully unpacked, I pray that the Buddha, looking with love and compassion, will explain it to me.

The Buddha then declared to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: Son of good family, shaving the hair and beard is for the sake of training the body so that there is no pride in it. Donning the Dharma robe is for the sake of being free from the ways of the ordinary. Maintaining complete ethical discipline is for the sake of attaining it and not letting it deteriorate. What I have described is indeed extraordinary, yet one who is able to tame body and mind — who is unshaken by pride and laziness, whose mind is unstained by dust, who has long been free from ordinary ways, who is like a vajra (Skt. vajra), whose very

nature of moral discipline is indestructible — though an ordinary person, that one is truly and properly a person who has gone forth from the household.

Furthermore, if one practices as taught in this text of Great Vehicle Dharma, and, trusting in the Dharma of the buddhas, continuously sees permanence, bliss, self, and purity, and explains this to sentient beings, then although such a one is an extraordinary person, that one is not a person of the four steadfasts. Yet, one who engages in the activities of a bodhisattva is worthy of receiving offerings, and the name for such a one is layman (Skt. *upāsaka*). Such a one has obtained the means of wisdom and teaches the Dharma of the Great Vehicle.

The essential nature of such Dharma is never separate from mind; it is born from the play of mind. In the stillness of meditative absorption, the mind that is ever singular is without duality. Within that singular mind there is neither outer nor inner; in the middle too there is no pride — it is free from all. When free from all, there is no birth and no death. When there is no birth and no death, it is, from the very beginning, the genuine unmoved. The genuine unmoved abides always, and the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha will never cease to exist. Sentient beings of the three realms are born of themselves and die of themselves.

Son of good family, I have deliberately taught that sentient beings are without a self. But the buddhas and the Sugatas are the genuine self of truth, transcending birth and death. You and all other sentient beings — if you seek to abide always, abandon what is desired, and engage in the activity of non-arising.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then asked the Buddha: Blessed One, what kind of practice is called "the activity of non-arising"?

The Buddha declared: Sons of good family, if other things do not arise from me, then I do not arise from other things. How so? The essential nature of the mode of things is pure and empty — it neither exists nor is it permanent. Everything that exists is in existence, yet its emptiness is pure — it neither does not exist, nor in the end does it exist either.

When bodhisattvas and buddhas, the Sugatas, purify the single essential nature of the mind of sentient beings by pervading it wholly with the fragrance of the single essential nature, the wise ones understand and penetrate to emptiness from within. Foolish ones enter into confusion and are bound by attachment. How so? Sentient beings who have wisdom, being free from

delusion, possess the essential nature of feeling. But when all that is ignorance is felt through feeling, the absence of feeling is unmoved. There is no emptiness either, no unchanging either — having penetrated into the sole purity, one is fully freed from all sorrow and affliction.

Sentient beings who are foolish, being possessed of delusion, do not feel the essential nature of feeling; ignorance is stirred up, and through the absence of feeling all dust and sorrow are generated. If one knows feeling to be present, then the absence of feeling is also gone. If the absence of feeling is also gone, then originally no illness arises either. If no illness arises, then the presence of feeling is also gone. The absence of the presence of feeling is the absence of the mind of disbelief. How so? Within a single mind of disbelief, there are two kinds of mind (Skt. *manas*).

If the mind of disbelief is absent, then illness too does not arise. If there is a place of arising, one enters an empty house. The genuine emptiness of a single essential nature has activity but no form; it meets with the sense bases. The stirring of causes is like emptiness resembling an illusion. The bodhisattva is of the kind whose purpose it is to cut through the mind of disbelief in all sentient beings. I aspire to be the master of mind. Mind does not aspire to be my master. Being separated from the objects of desire and having left oneself unimpaired, even though a place of intended thought arises, there is no mind of rejection. Because former mind and later mind contradict one another, proceeding as they do, ignorance does not stir. Though feeling undergoes change, the later one does not stir. When mind stirs, the unstirred prior mind blocks it. The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha (Treasury of Space) addressed the Buddha with this question: Blessed One, if mind stirs prior to mind, by what Dharma can one feel it and block it? The Buddha declared that among bodhisattvas who are engaged in action, those in whom mind is dwelling should be made to observe: if one knows the place where mind dwells, originally mind is not dwelling there. By feeling in this way, one blocks feeling. If the mind of desire does not stir, then even when one examines and analyses it, there is nothing there. If there is a place of stirring, one rests at ease in emptiness. Within a single emptiness of essential nature, both the defiled and the pure are equally absent. Because the essential nature is intrinsically pure and clear, there is nothing to be taken up and nothing to be abandoned. Mind too does not arise. There is no arising. There is no conduct. There is no place for conduct performed by the body. The path of speech and words is cut off. The sacred essential nature of the buddhas — the essential nature of feeling —

is permanently present; it is like an example of emptiness and is unattached to all things. If a bodhisattva practises this, it is like striking the sky with a finger: there is contact, there is contact, yet no attachment. This is called practising the Dharma. If there is a place of attachment, one has entered what is inner and outer. Travelling and proceeding along pure ground, the mind is one, without duality. Enter meditative concentration and block the mind of arising exhaustion. Examining a single genuine truth, one should confess and repent. At that time, among the multitude there is one called a perverse craving — a name meaning one who lusts for what is wrong — who, from beginningless time until now, has done wrong repeatedly, has made the ten misdeeds a constant practice, and is driven by hatred, anger, envy, and rivalry. These four are drawn on by snakes. Two rats — the mind of dishonesty and the outward-turned mind — cut the root of mind. It is like a person suspended over a tree trunk with four snakes below, whose poisonous breath is blown upward, while two rats from the top of the tree gnaw at the root of the rope on which he hangs until it breaks. The three purities of mind are eliminated. The eye, complexion, and mind — all are made dishonest and perverted, and bound by what is seen, one falls headlong into hell. Then, within the mind of an instant's thought, a mind stirred by harm and resentment arises. If one wonders whether one should ask the Tathāgata for a Dharma of confession and repentance, yet is oppressed in mind and, out of shame, does not dare to ask, the miraculous wisdom of the Tathāgata knows what that person is thinking in his mind. Considering how to draw that person out of suffering and rescue him from the gateway of hell, the Tathāgata addressed the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha and declared: After I have passed away, there will be those of perverse craving who have committed many evil deeds and have destroyed the Three Jewels of the buddhas. Such people, in a future time, will fall squarely into hell and will not be liberated for as long as twelve great aeons.

You bodhisattvas, who practice loving-kindness and compassion, should enable sentient beings such as these to perform genuine repentance, purify the stains of their minds, and bring them to liberation and freedom.

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha then addressed the Buddha: Blessed One, if one performs the practice of genuine repentance, what must be done so that evil may be purified? With loving-kindness and compassion the Buddha beholds all. I pray that he will explain this in precise and particular detail.

The Buddha declared to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: In order to perform genuine repentance, one should examine the principle of perfect truth. If one

sees the principle of perfect truth, all evils whatsoever are purified.

When the Buddha had finished speaking these words, at that moment many hundreds and thousands and tens of thousands and hundreds of thousands of sentient beings, human and non-human and all the rest, each with one-pointed mind, examined that single principle of perfect truth. Having seen it, those of perverse craving, even in the midst of their desires, rose up from their seats, placed the five lower parts of their bodies on the ground in prostration, and addressed the Buddha: Blessed One, because ignorance dwells in our minds, though we have endeavored to inquire and learn, we have not seen the principle of perfect truth. From beginningless time until now we have committed nothing but the ten non-virtues. What means should we now employ so that we might see the principle of perfect truth and so that our evils may be confessed and purified?

The Buddha declared to those of perverse craving: Let all of you whose craving is perverse gather your minds into one, and I will explain this to you in precise and particular detail.

You sentient beings of perverse craving and all the rest: if, with body and mind, you examine the single essential nature of the buddha, the essential nature of the Dharma too is one alone. The essential nature of all buddhas as well is one alone. Because there is no duality, this is the principle of perfect truth. If one sees it as existing in two, that is called deviation. When one looks with deviation, grief and disturbance arise. If there is no seeing of deviation, grief and disturbance do not arise either. When grief and disturbance are cut through, that is called purity. All of you sentient beings should, with one-pointed mind, realize the single essential nature of the buddha. There is simply no arising of seeing anything other than the essential nature of the buddha. Even if there were seeing of something other, all of it would be illusion and unreal. To engage in such unreality is called perversion. Perverse craving: when the one mind is pure, all phenomena whatsoever are pure. When the one mind is defiled, all phenomena whatsoever are defiled. The defilement of defilement is evil. Purity is what is genuine. When the mind is free from defilement, evil does not arise.

Those of perverse craving then addressed the Buddha: Blessed One, the evil actions we have committed from of old are beyond counting, beyond the measure of tens of thousands of aeons and without limit — yet today we have aroused our minds. I pray that the Buddha will explain decisively whether all

boundless evils are purified or not when one examines that single principle of perfect truth.

The Buddha declared to those of perverse craving: If one realizes the principle of perfect truth, all evils whatsoever are purified. On what account is this known? O you of perverse craving, formerly you had a defiled mind. Now you have a pure mind. The mind is one; there is no duality, and apart from that there is no other mind. If today's mind is pure, then the former mind was pure as well. Therefore all the evils accumulated over incalculable aeons are fully purified and manifestly absent.

As an analogy: a mirror that has accumulated a thousand years of dust — when one wipes it once with a cloth, the reflection appears in the mirror in that very instant. It is just as if all the dust has been wiped away and not even a remainder is left.

Here is another analogy: it is like a single lamp lit inside a room that has been dark for a thousand years — all the darkness is gone at once.

It is fitting that you and other sentient beings should at all times, with a single mind, examine and reflect upon the true teaching of authentic truth. It is fitting to engage in the inner work of all the Dharma teachings and thereby to be liberated from all the phenomena of the world. Why is this? Phenomena tainted by desire — whether they stir or remain still — all ultimately perish and disintegrate. When the Dharma perishes and disintegrates, there is likewise no permanence in one's practice, and the Dharma comes to have birth and death. When one is free of the Dharma that has birth and death, that alone is called from the very beginning the teaching of authentic truth.

As for desire, consider the analogy of a potter working with clay: whatever is made according to the wish of the mind undergoes change and transformation, and from those clay forms, all shapes and names are born and then disperse. Only the nature of the clay itself remains — that single intrinsic nature alone endures permanently. All other clay forms are born and then disperse. A form that is born and disperses has not arisen by itself. What has not arisen by itself does not truly exist.

O you of perverse craving, the essential nature of a buddha is analogous to the clay itself. The intrinsic nature of sentient beings is analogous to the vessels, for it belongs to the Dharma of birth and death. When one is free of all karma, there is but one body of a buddha, and if one examines that single body of a buddha, there is no other body.

O you of perverse craving, asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if through my examination of the teaching of authentic truth all evils are purified, then through what practice is it fitting that a dharma body be born?"

The Buddha declared to the one of perverse craving: "When one examines the teaching of authentic truth, all illness does not arise. When evil and defilement are utterly unmoved, the mind is like a vajra and can never be destroyed. When one is able to uphold moral discipline, the mind is like space — both outer and inner are thoroughly pure. When one is skilled in entering into the gathering of meditative concentration, the mind is like wind and fire, burning away every last trace of unwholesome karma. When one is skilled in relying upon wisdom, it is fitting that wisdom be attained, and that is called liberation and freedom. Through liberation and freedom, one is able to know and see what is authentic and true."

O you of perverse craving, if you are able to purify and practice a meaning such as this, it is fitting to attain the five aspects of the dharma body.

The one of perverse craving asked the Buddha: "Blessed One, what are the cause and the result of the five aspects of the dharma body?"

The Buddha declared to the one of perverse craving: "The essential nature of a buddha is the permanent cause. The dharma body is the permanent result. How is this? The cause of mind is the essential nature of a buddha, and through the virtues of the Dharma the result is attained. When cause and result are absent, there is no result of any cause. When neither cause nor result exists, the body of a buddha is authentic."

O you of perverse craving, when, in the domain of pure mind, one thinks of Amitāyus with an unmoving mind, one is born from the very beginning in a pure realm. For the sake of sentient beings, one teaches the Dharma of non-movement, and the mind, having entered into the emptiness of authentic truth, is free from stirring and conceptual explanation. The essential nature of the three kinds of knowing is one, and like a vajra it is indestructible.

At that time, among the great assembly there was a bodhisattva named Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct who rose from his seat, bared his right shoulder in the proper manner, placed his right knee upon the ground, joined his palms together, and addressed the Buddha:

"Blessed One, after a buddha has passed away and departed — whether five hundred years, or one thousand, or fifteen hundred years later — when one



teaches the Dharma to sentient beings, whatever Dharma is taught: may the buddha, with love and compassionate regard, reveal and explain it to me directly."

The Buddha then spoke to the bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct:

"Son of good family, when one teaches the Dharma, it is the meaning that is taught, not the written letter. It is the text that is taught, not the marks of script. To teach in just this way is authentic Dharma. If one teaches the marks of script and the written letter, one is stirring one's mouth and stirring one's mind — and all of that is a burden and a corruption. Son of good family, when teaching the Dharma to all sentient beings, teach it as one who does not stir, teach it in an even and equable manner.

"How so? The mind of all sentient beings is one, and the essential nature of a buddha is likewise one. When one is even and equable in that single essential nature, then all phenomena are likewise even and equable. To teach them as high or low is what is called 'teaching what is crooked' — one's mouth is cracked and one's tongue is split. Why? Because the defilement of the minds of all sentient beings is concordantly one defilement, and the purity of the minds of all sentient beings is concordantly one purity. Why? The minds of all sentient beings are purely one — they are in concordant purity through the ten virtuous phenomena. If the minds of all sentient beings are defiled as one, they are concordantly defiled through the ten non-virtuous phenomena. The disease of sentient beings is concordantly one; and if sentient beings need medicine, the medicine too is needed as one. To teach many Dharmas is called 'teaching in an inverted manner.' Why? It is to make false distinctions; it is to destroy the virtuous and non-virtuous phenomena, shattering a single Dharma. To teach one Dharma while it exists — that is to teach the buddha's Dharma-path.

"When a bodhisattva teaches the Dharma, teach it as one who does not stir."

The bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct then asked the Buddha:

"Blessed One, how should I teach as one who does not stir?"

The Buddha spoke to the bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct:

"Son of good family, to teach the single Dharma of authentic truth — that is to teach as one who does not stir. To teach with mind fully upright and complete — that is to teach as one who does not stir. To teach without attachment to any single extreme — that is to teach as one who does not stir. To teach

without making distinctions or divisions — that is to teach as one who does not stir. To teach while abiding in the single purity of mind — that is to teach as one who does not stir. When all that is taught is taught as not taught — that is to teach as one who does not stir."

Then, in order to make all the many ordinary sentient beings understand and comprehend the distinction, the bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct again asked the Buddha:

"In what manner of teaching is what is taught not taught — and how is that called teaching as one who does not stir?"

The Buddha spoke to the bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct:

"Son of good family, because the form that is the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is empty, they are liberated and there is nothing to teach. Because all phenomena are without form, they are liberated with respect to form and there is nothing to teach — it is not fitting to teach. Because all phenomena have no activity and no stirring, to speak of liberation from non-activity is not fitting to teach. Son of good family, liberation-speech is taught in just that way. And because that teaching is not fitting to teach, it is called teaching as one who does not stir."

The bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct then asked the Buddha:

"Blessed One, since the Dharma is taught in just that way, how then is one to teach with mind fully upright and complete?"

The Buddha then declared to the bodhisattva Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct:

"What is called 'mind fully upright' means teaching with an upright mind — setting forth what the Tathāgata (the thus-gone one) has established in faithfulness, without teaching according to one's own mind.

What is called 'complete' means: complete in the teaching of the ten virtues; complete in the teaching of the Four Noble Truths; complete in the teaching of the twelve links of cause and condition; complete in the teaching of the six perfections; and complete in the teaching of liberation and freedom. When such Dharmas are complete, if one teaches a single mind as pure, the essential nature of a buddha as single, and a single purity as equanimous — that teaching is called complete, and it is said to be taught as one who does not stir. How is this to be understood? Because all phenomena whatsoever are taught as wholly and completely one. The bodhisattva brings all phenomena to

purity as one. It is like a great ocean in which precious jewels of many kinds exist within the water, and one who seeks them finds them just as one's heart desires. Again, it is like a magical medicinal compound called 'medicine of perfect qualities' prepared from many kinds of medicinal ingredients: when it heals every illness, it is as though all are cured by a single medicine administered.

When the heart is brought to a single purity, the mind is single and pure; the essential nature of a buddha is single and pure; the natures of the Dharma are single and pure. When there is equanimity, the natures of Dharma are equalized. To teach in just this way is to teach with purity. To teach otherwise is to teach with blemish. How is this to be understood? Because all sentient beings, every one, possess the essential nature of a buddha. There is none who lacks the essential nature of a buddha — there is only the near and far of feeling. It is like the pattern of root and branch: to a person of the lesser vehicle one teaches the Dharma of the lesser vehicle; if one teaches the Dharma of wrong craving to a person of wrong craving, that is called teaching the path of the Buddha's Dharma as crooked — proclaiming the essential nature of a buddha and yet teaching as though the body of a buddha were absent. A person who teaches Dharma in such a way will fall into the hells for ten thousand hundreds of thousands of aeons. Even if a buddha arises in the world, such a one is not liberated. And if by chance liberation comes and one is born among humans, one is born at the outermost margins of the land, among the very lowest of people, and one obtains such a body as has a harelip, a cleft palate, and no tongue. How is this to be understood? Because, for a bodhisattva, the essential nature of sentient beings is the essential nature of phenomena. The essential nature of phenomena is forever pure, endowed with every truly good characteristic and mark, neither gained from outside nor ever lost — never arisen, never perished. Its essential nature is eternal and truly real. There is no illusion, no falsehood. There is no agitation of sorrow. There is no passing beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa. There is no emptying-out, and it is timelessly and endlessly pure. Being pure in a single essential nature is awakening itself. The essential nature of that purity and the essential nature of awakening are simply one; they are not two. It is equanimity in purity: even the path of syllables and words is cut off. It is, for example, like space — both inner and outer are pure. That purity alone does not abide inside, does not abide outside, does not abide in between. It cannot be spoken; it cannot be explained. And yet, just as within that, one distinguishes the specific

properties of medicinal essences — when there is no distinction to be made, that is the wisdom of making distinctions. Son of good family, a single mind, a single purity, and a single essential nature of a buddha — apart from these there is no buddha to seek, no Dharma to teach, and no Saṅgha to attain. How so? The buddha is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha."

Therefore I have taught this Dharma text by saying: a single body of a sentient being, a single mind, a single purity, a single essential nature of a buddha, a single Dharma of a buddha — through a single trunk of awakening, all realms in their entirety are pervaded and enter within the bodies of all sentient beings. Son of good family, all buddhas are born from this Dharma text. All phenomena whatsoever arise from this Dharma text. All members of the Saṅgha as well appear from this Dharma text. To retain and hold this Dharma text in mind is called, by name, holding the Three Jewels. If one reads this Dharma text and causes others to read its teachings extensively, then even if some among them are sick, all shall recover, and malevolent spirits, possessing demons, and evil ones will have no power to draw near.

Bodhisattva, because you possess such great benefit for sentient beings, I have entrusted this Dharma text to you and confided it in you. Know this as one: for sentient beings there is a way to benefit and liberate them — through hearing a little of the Dharma, one comes to know much; through seeing a little, one comes to understand much; and without seeking out many written letters, one attains the signs of the teaching's meaning. Let me explain this further. You and all the bodhisattvas: listen, and examine this as one mind. I shall explain it to you as a liberation.

All sentient beings are one mind, one buddha, one essential nature. All the agitations of sorrow arise from a single mind. All of them arise from causes rooted in the ground of both sense-bases (āyatanas) and wisdom. How so? From the intrinsic nature of cause, from the intrinsic nature of self, and from the stirring of the natures of powers through the force of these two natures, in a single moment of thought a mind of untruth arises — and that untruth has no subsequent moment. The very instant the mind stirs, the agitation of sorrow rises simultaneously. Yet when one examines this mind, the mind of untruth has no subsequent moment. If it has no subsequent moment, it has no abiding place. When one recognizes that it has no place of abiding, a mind of feeling arises — and thereafter no thought moves toward the pure mind of feeling. When there is no thought moving in the mind, the mind does not stir. When the mind does not stir, the mind also has no place of abiding. That is what is

called purity.

The empty mind of purity is pure from the very essential nature of its being, without remainder. Nor is there anything discerned by purity itself. Since it is free even from the mind of purity, it is called pure. For the bodhisattva, in the mind of purity there is no activity, no stirring, no stain, no cleanliness, no arising, no diminishing, and in the end no defilement of any kind. It does not dwell in any single place, and it is free from name and enumeration. Though it abides permanently as it is, there is not even a "suchness" to speak of. It is like the vajra — in its single essential nature there is nothing that can destroy it. It is like space — it contains everything. It is like a lotus flower — it is not defiled by the water of craving. Practicing this conduct, one is perfectly liberated, transcending the stream of birth and death, and released from the suffering of the hells of sentient beings.

The bodhisattva — this doctrine of the single mind has a first name: liberation through blameless brahmic purity, because one sees the true, authentic foundation. Its second name is: liberation through practicing the Dharma, because one abides in a single forest. Its third name is: liberation through the absence of practice, because one abides without attachment. These three liberations all arise from the single mind, for in all sentient beings the mind is non-dual. For all sentient beings, there is but one single vehicle. The bodhisattva — the Dharma king of Dharma — if one can know this one Dharma, there is no Dharma one does not know.

If one does not know this one Dharma, there is not a single Dharma one knows. Why is that? Because there is nothing among phenomena that is not unified. If a bodhisattva hears only this one thing, that is to be considered having heard little. The name for knowing no Dharma to be unknown is: having heard much. Why is that? Because the essential nature of all phenomena whatsoever is gathered into one single purity. It is because one sees this singularity alone. And if one sees this singularity alone, one sees the body of all buddhas. Why is that? Because the body of all buddhas without exception arises from this one single purity. Through this one single purity, there is one body of a single buddha, one ground of buddha, and one stem of awakening.

Noble son, within this Dharma, cutting off those whose sorrow is disturbed is like cutting a tree at the trunk: one cuts only the root, and does not cut the branches and leaves. Why is that? It is like a man struck in the body by a poisoned arrow: if, while the body is afflicted by sickness, the arrow is drawn

out, the illness too is healed. If the arrow is not drawn out, the illness too is not healed. If one were to sit there inquiring what feathers are on that arrow, of what single kind they are, from what thicket of reeds the arrow came, and who shot the arrow — by the time all that is asked, that person's life will have been exhausted by the affliction of the illness. Thereafter drawing out the arrow is manifestly of no benefit.

Noble son, while mind is present, bathe! If mind abides in purity, the name for that is purity and cleansing. Among the sense bases (āyatanas), those in which purity and cleansing are present become separated from those that are attached to existence, and are able to enter into the state free from attachment. Why is that? Instructing sentient beings at the end, proclaiming this excellent medicine, one heals the sick and aspires that all be healed.

Again, in yet another way, this textual Dharma, with the vajra sword of wisdom, cleaves the minds of ignorance of sentient beings. Again, in yet another way, this textual Dharma, practicing the Dharma of purity and cleansing, strikes and removes the stains of the three poisons from sentient beings. Again, in yet another way, this textual Dharma, practicing the great power of wisdom, aspires to liberate and free sentient beings who are bound and fettered by the ten entanglements. Again, in yet another way, this textual Dharma, practicing as the single essential nature of purity and cleansing, aspires that all sentient beings attain one body, one mind, one buddha, one essential nature, one purity and cleansing, and enter truly and fully into the vehicle of the teaching. It aspires that mind be perfectly liberated from the hells of sentient beings.

I am capable of being the arrow of liberation for my sentient beings. If sentient beings fall into the hells of sentient beings, I aspire that the Blessed One entrust and instruct me in these buddha-Dharmas, making the body of the Buddha fade and become absent. And proclaiming to me also the vast liberation of sentient beings, I aspire that the Blessed One, with love and compassionate gaze, explain liberation to me, so that sentient beings hear little yet know much, see little yet realize much, seek not an abundance of textual learning yet attain a clear sign of the teaching, and by a small amount of Dharma are perfectly liberated and freed, without need to ask others out of doubt.

The Buddha declared to the great assembly: this bodhisattva, the Dharma king of Dharma, having in the past made offerings to buddhas of hundreds of

thousands of tens of millions of eons, is skilled in applying skillful means and is able to be the arrow of liberation for sentient beings and to liberate them. This bodhisattva, employing the breath that permeates and courses, is able to sustain the life of sentient beings. You and all sentient beings of the present and future time who hold the name of this bodhisattva as a dhāraṇī, guided by a great spiritual friend, will attain liberation and freedom, unobstructed, in the emptiness of the Perfection of Wisdom that transcends nirvāṇa.

Then the bodhisattva Dharma King touched the ground with his head in prostration, rose, and from that very basis entered into the great nirvāṇa. Liberated and freed through emptiness, he lifted each foot and set each foot down across the ground of non-attachment — every step perfectly pure — and, placing his palms together, prostrated to the Buddha and departed.

The single-volume scripture of the holy Dharma King is complete.

This appears to be an old translation from Chinese, unaltered by revision into the new language.

## Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered as "five turbidities" is a standard Mahāyāna concept referring to the five degenerations of a corrupt age. The phrase "limbs of desire" is a somewhat unusual idiom in the text; it likely refers to the constituent factors or supports of desire. The final question by Ākāśagarbha about "outer and inner, both extremes" entering into one another is grammatically compressed in the Tibetan; the translation represents the most coherent doctrinal reading, namely that all conditioned phenomena of both categories are mutually interdependent. The term rendered as "responses and reactions" translates a phrase meaning literally "responses arising in return," suggesting karmic reciprocity. The closing phrase of Ākāśagarbha's question is slightly lacunose in the Tibetan as given, ending mid-construction; the translation represents the intended sense.

- The phrase rendered "make these four kinds of people the target of a single arrow" translates a metaphor using "ra mda'" (arrow of a boundary-marker or target stake), meaning to aim a single teaching at all four types simultaneously. The image is of a single stake or marker that fixes the target for all — the translation captures the rhetorical force of the question without requiring technical elaboration.

The term "མཐོང་ལྷན་འཁོར་ལོ་" is rendered "middle vehicle," referring to the pratyekabuddha vehicle, positioned between the Great Vehicle and the lesser vehicle in this threefold schema.

- The phrase rendered "the mother of mind" reflects the Tibetan མཐོང་ལྷན་འཁོར་ལོ་, where མཐོང་ལྷན་ can mean "grandmother" or "ancestral mother" and may carry the sense of the root or ultimate ground of mind; the translation "mother of mind" is chosen as the most natural reading in context, though "ancestral source of mind" is possible.

The passage's repeated logic, "if the mind does not abide anywhere, that very thing is named the abiding of the mind," is a deliberate paradox in the original text about the ultimately non-locatable yet primordially present nature of mind. No smoothing has been applied.





- The phrase rendered throughout as "the principle of perfect truth" translates the Tibetan yang dag pa'i bden pa'i gzhung, literally "the basis or course of genuine/perfect truth." This is the text's distinctive term for the ultimate nature of mind and reality as nondual — essentially pointing to what other texts might call the nature of mind, buddha-nature, or suchness. The translation "principle of perfect truth" is chosen to maintain consistency and the text's own register, though a rendering such as "the teaching of genuine truth" or "the foundation of perfect truth" would also be defensible.

The five-point prostration (lus smad lnga sa la gtugs) refers to the traditional full prostration in which both knees, both forearms or palms, and the forehead touch the ground.

- The phrase rendered "the three kinds of knowing" translates "shes pa gsum gyi ngo bo nyid gcig" and likely refers to a set of three modes or objects of knowledge specific to the doctrinal context of this text; the precise referent is not fully determined from the passage alone, though "knowing" or "gnosis" in three aspects is a reasonable rendering.

The five aspects of the dharma body mentioned here are a schema particular to this text's tradition; they are not glossed further in the passage, and no enumeration is given, so no expansion is supplied.

The bodhisattva's name, rendered "Untraceable-in-Name-and-Conduct," translates the Tibetan ming spyod med, a descriptive compound name.

- The phrase rendered "liberation-speech" or "liberation and speech" translates "dgrol bshad pa," a compound that appears to mean something like "teachings of liberation" or "explanatory liberation-teaching." The text uses this term three times in close succession in a manner suggesting it is a technical category within this text's framework. The rendering chosen keeps the term coherent across the three occurrences without importing meaning not present in the Tibetan.

The phrase "one's mouth is cracked and one's tongue is split" is a striking idiom for false or perverse speech; it is rendered literally as the image appears intentional and is intelligible in context.

- The phrase rendered "harelip, cleft palate, and no tongue" translates a list of physical defects associated with the karmic consequence of teaching Dharma falsely. The exact anatomical terms in the Tibetan are somewhat unusual, and the rendering follows the most natural interpretation.

The expression "pattern of root and branch" renders a Tibetan idiom meaning a sequential or graduated hierarchy, here applied to matching the level of teaching to the capacity of the student; it is a slightly compressed image and the rendering is interpretive but doctrinally coherent.

The term rendered throughout as "essential nature" is the Tibetan ngobonyid (svabhāva), but in this text it carries a strongly positive, buddha-nature valence rather than the Madhyamaka sense of inherently existing essence; this dual resonance is intentional in the source and is preserved without disambiguation.

- The phrase rendered "sense-bases and wisdom" translates a compound that appears to read "the place of sense-bases (āyatana) and wisdom" as the locus from which samsaric agitation arises. The passage is philosophically dense and the syntax in this section is compressed; the rendering follows the most natural grammatical reading while preserving the doctrinal sense.

The three names for liberation near the end involve some unusual terminology. "Liberation through blameless brahmic purity" renders a term that literally combines "remorse/regret" and

"brahmic" with liberation, suggesting a pure, unstained release; "single forest" for the second liberation is the literal reading and likely carries a contemplative metaphor of non-distraction. These renderings are the most defensible given the text but should be noted as interpretively engaged choices.

- The phrase rendered as "the breath that permeates and courses" translates "ro bro ba'i rlung" literally as "the breath/wind that percolates or oozes," a somewhat unusual expression. It likely refers to a vitalizing or animating force — perhaps a tantric or yogic notion of prāṇa — but the exact nuance is uncertain in this context.

The phrase "enter into the vehicle of the teaching" is grammatically compact; "joint, segment, or measure" can mean a joint, segment, or measure, and the full sense may be "enter into the joint or core of the vehicle," though "vehicle of the teaching" is the most natural reading here.

The closing aspiration passage, in which the bodhisattva speaks of making "the body of the Buddha fade and become absent" as a condition, is doctrinally striking and may reflect a vow formula in which the speaker stakes the Buddha's own form-body against the liberation of beings — a rhetorical intensification of the bodhisattva vow rather than a literal doctrinal claim.

- The final two lines are colophon remarks rather than part of the narrative proper. The first states the text is complete as a single-volume scripture. The second is an editorial or scribal note indicating that this appears to be an older translation from Chinese that was not revised or modified when the new translation conventions were adopted — a common colophon notice found in early Tibetan translations predating the standardized terminology reforms of the imperial and post-imperial periods.

## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.